



The Humanitas Institute

## Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Life Challenge Academy  
School Website: <https://www.lcodessa.org/>

December 27, 2025

---

**Disclaimer**

*This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.*

**ACCS Member School**

*Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) or the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.*

## Executive Summary

Life Challenge Academy TX 79762, based on the public content available from Life Challenge U.P.C. (Odessa, TX), demonstrates a strong religious/theological orientation and liturgical/community life typical of a church ministry rather than a formal classical school built on the Six Essential Elements. Across the six classical categories, the site strongly confirms Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations) and shows limited alignment with the other five categories (Curriculum, Pedagogy, Faculty, Parents & Community, and to a lesser extent, School Purpose and Goal). The overall classification, using the classical rubric, is NOT CLASSICAL. The evidence shows robust theological framing, explicit scriptural authority, and communal worship, but an absence of the core liberal-arts curriculum, Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, Socratic pedagogy, a formal "living curriculum" with virtuous teacher-mentors, and explicit parent-as-co-educators partnerships typical of classical schools.

Key takeaway: Life Challenge Academy TX 79762 presents a vibrant religious community and mission orientation, rather than a classical education model. To move toward a CLASSICAL profile, the school would need to adopt a formal liberal-arts curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric; history through a Great Books lens), implement Socratic pedagogy in upper grades, articulate a robust formation-focused goal (virtue, wisdom, and human flourishing) beyond evangelistic aims, and establish a sustained parent-community partnership in the classical sense.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

### Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site centers on scriptural authority, with explicit statements about Scripture as the Word of God and the Bible as infallible. For example, the mission statements articulate belief in the authority of Scripture as the inspired Word of God and the necessity of repentance and baptism for salvation. This is visible in the public mission language and statements about God, Jesus, and salvation. - The material emphasizes worship, communal practices, and ministries (e.g., Kid Challenge, Student Ministry, Music, LC Español), signaling liturgical and communal rhythms as central to life, which aligns with liturgical/cohesive religious life but not necessarily with a classical metaphysical framework in the sense of liberal-arts formation. - The public materials repeatedly anchor education and formation in biblical authority, salvation doctrine, and the Word of God rather than in an explicitly transcendent, classical synthesis of truth, goodness, and beauty as ends of education beyond religious faith.

Positive keyword analysis - Present: scriptural authority, Word of God, Bible, gospel/mission, worship, prayer, salvation, Jesus, plan to visit (community formation). - From the classical rubric, these align with Grounded in Theology and Liturgical/Communal Practices under Religious Foundations.

Negative keyword analysis - Notably absent are explicit references to transcendental moral realism expressed in standard classical terms (e.g., truth, virtue, beauty as ultimate ideals beyond religious doctrine), and there is no explicit articulation of liturgical practices in the educational sense (e.g., a formal chapel calendar, liturgical year in pedagogy). The never-explicit reference to "great books," "classical dialogue," or a structured liturgical pedagogy is missing.

---

Why this rating - The strongest signals are theological and ecclesial rather than classical education signals. The school does not present a classical pedagogy in the sense of forming virtue through a transcendent curriculum, but rather a church-centered formation anchored in Scripture and Christian doctrine, which, while deeply meaningful, does not fulfill the full spectrum of Classical Foundations per the Six Essentials.

Citations - Mission statement and scriptural authority: Life Challenge U.P.C. content emphasizing Scripture as the Word of God. - The Word as foundational (biblical authority and doctrinal articulation): "We are founded upon the belief that the Bible is the inspired, infallible Word of God."

## **Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — NOT CLASSICAL**

Evidence - The public statements emphasize knowing Jesus Christ and making Him known, i.e., evangelistic and spiritual formation goals, rather than a classical telos centered on virtue, wisdom, and contemplation for its own sake. The core mission reads as evangelistic and faith formation-focused rather than paideia-oriented formation in virtue and wisdom as classical aims.

Positive keyword analysis - Present: fulfillment of a religious telos (knowing Christ, making Him known); spiritual formation; salvation framework; plan to visit. - Positive keywords per classical rubric would be limited to formation and virtue in the sense of spiritual formation, but the explicit aim is more evangelistic and doctrinal than classical (virtue formation, contemplation, and pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty as enduring ends).

Negative keyword analysis - Classic aims such as paideia, formation of character through wisdom, and the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty as non-religious transcendent aims are not foregrounded. - No explicit mention of liberal education, Great Books, or a comprehensive formation of intellect and character beyond religious doctrine.

Why this rating - While the school claims formation in a religious sense (formation through faith and doctrine), it does not foreground the classical telos (virtue, wisdom, and beauty as universal, knowable transcendentals). The goals are primarily religious/spiritual rather than classical.

Citations - Evangelistic/spiritual formation focus: "To Know Jesus Christ and to Make Him Known." - Mission alignment and Word-of-God framework: "MISSION STATEMENT... Scripture as the inspired Word of God."

## **Element 3: Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL**

Evidence - There is no explicit liberal arts curriculum described (no mention of grammar, logic, rhetoric, history through a Great Books framework, Latin/Greek, or the Great Conversation). The site focuses on ministries, services, and church life rather than a K–12 curriculum structure built on Trivium/Quadrivium or Great Books.

Positive keyword analysis - Present: mentions of "ministry," "Bible," "Word of God," "Salvation," "Gospel," "Sermons." These are religious content markers rather than liberal-arts curriculum markers.

Negative keyword analysis - Absence of: seven liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy), Great Books, primary sources, classical canon, Latin/Greek, and an integrated cross-disciplinary curriculum.

Why this rating - The public materials do not articulate a classical curriculum. They emphasize doctrinal instruction, worship, and ministry rather than a structured classical curriculum in line with Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, and cross-disciplinary integration.

Citations - Content emphasizes ministries and religious instruction rather than classical curriculum: "ministries," "Gospel," "Word of God," and "Sermons."

---

#### **Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL**

Evidence - The materials show a church-based, ministry-driven approach rather than classical pedagogy. There is no explicit reference to Socratic seminars, dialectic, or structured liberal-arts pedagogy. The emphasis is on worship, ministry involvement, sermon-style teaching, and religious instruction.

Positive keyword analysis - Present: worship-based pedagogy (praise/worship in service; sermons; ministry leadership). Elements of “lectures”/sermon style are present, and “ministry” roles function as a form of mentoring/instruction within a religious community.

Negative keyword analysis - Absence of Socratic dialogue, scholé, memory work, recitation, or formal formation through imitation and practice in literature/history/mathematics; no explicit lower-to-upper school progression with classical pedagogy.

Why this rating - The pedagogical approach is not described in classical terms (no Socratic seminars, no recitation/memorization regime, no master-apprentice classical pedagogy). It aligns more with church instruction and ministry-based formation than with classical education pedagogy.

Citations - The presence of sermon-style instruction and ministry-based teaching: examples include “Sermons,” “Ministries,” and “We know Jesus Christ and Make Him Known.”

#### **Element 5: Faculty — NOT CLASSICAL**

Evidence - The materials show pastoral leadership (Pastor Dan Smelser, Brian & Marie Jones as ministry leaders) but do not present a “living curriculum” or a formal “faculty portrait” of teachers as virtuous exemplars or a faculty community of mentors in the classical sense. The public materials do not describe teacher-mentors in the classical sense or a formal teacher profile.

Positive keyword analysis - Present: named ministry leaders and pastoral leadership; emphasis on leaders as mentors within a church context.

Negative keyword analysis - Absence of language about “model teachers and mentors who model virtue,” “living curriculum,” or “faculty portrait” that codifies teacher expectations in the classical sense.

Why this rating - The leadership imagery centers on pastors and ministry leaders rather than a formal “faculty” with a classical formation and a defined living curriculum.

Citations - Public leadership language (Pastor Dan Smelser; leadership in ministries).

#### **Element 6: Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**

Evidence - The site communicates a community-centric religious life with formal weekly gatherings, plan-a-visit messaging, and family-oriented ministry structures (Kid Challenge, Student Ministry, LC Español) and invites families to participate. There is mention of “bring your family” and a plan to visit, but there is limited explicit language about parents as co-educators or formal parental formation in the classical sense.

Positive keyword analysis - Present: partnership with families in the sense of family involvement in ministries; welcoming families to worship and participate; open to visits; various family-oriented ministries (Kids, Students, Young Adults).

Negative keyword analysis - Absence of explicit parent-as-co-teachers language, formal family formation programs, home-school or family catechesis models, or living-partner language that classical schools use to frame parent involvement.

Why this rating - The public materials show active family inclusion and a family-oriented church environment, which aligns with a community orientation but lacks the explicit, classical-parent-partner formation language (parent as co-educator) and a culture of household formation that classical schools emphasize. Hence, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully Classical.

---

Citations - Family/ministry involvement and welcome language; plan-a-visit and family-oriented ministry structure: Kid Challenge, Student Ministry, Young Adult Ministry; “bring your family”; “Plan Your Visit.”

#### Aggregate Assessment

- Overall classification: NOT CLASSICAL.
- Rationale: Across Categories 2–5, the public materials do not exhibit the liberal-arts curriculum (trivium/quadrivium), Great Books, Socratic pedagogy, or a living-portrait of classical teachers. Element 1 is the strongest traditional signal, given the explicit theology and liturgical practices, but classical education requires a multi-category alignment toward a liberal-arts formation, which is not evidenced in these materials. Element 6 is only SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, not enough to shift the aggregate toward CLASSICAL.

#### What Would Move the Needle

- If this school aimed to become CLASSICAL, concrete changes would include:
  - Curriculum: Introduce a formal liberal-arts core (grammar, logic, rhetoric; history through Great Books; Latin or classical languages; study of Western canon; integration of Trivium and Quadrivium principles).
  - Pedagogy: Adopt Socratic seminars and dialectic, and implement structured memory work (recitation, chanting) consistent with scholé; establish a master-teacher model with a living curriculum.
  - Formation and Goals: Articulate a translatable telos focused on truth, goodness, and beauty as ends of education, with formation of character in addition to doctrinal instruction.
  - Faculty: Develop a “living curriculum” profile for teachers, with clear exemplars of virtue, mentorship, and classical expertise; create faculty seminars and ongoing formation in classical pedagogy.
  - Curriculum Integration: Emphasize integration across subjects (interdisciplinary study, cross-curricular themes, the unity of truth) and the Great Books as central to the curriculum.
  - Parents & Community: Forge explicit parent-partnership plans in the classical sense (parents as co-educators, home-school catechesis, book studies for families, letters and gatherings that train parents in classical methods).
- Concrete steps could include partnering with classical education organizations, adopting a classical accreditation/assessment approach, and creating a formal “classical program” track within Life Challenge’s existing ministry framework.

Note: The needle-moving recommendations are presented only because the aggregate assessment here is NOT CLASSICAL. If the school remains at NOT CLASSICAL, no further needle-moving strategies are required beyond the above to stage a transition toward CLASSICAL.

---

# Appendix

## ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

### Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

By reading or using this document, you acknowledge and accept the limitations described above.